Initially I thought I am biased towards Russians because of the instant rapport I could establish with every Russian I met, despite the language barrier. When I shared this to my colleagues during private conversations, many of them shared my view. The core reason for this feeling of brethren, however, remained unanswered.

I had met a few Russian scientists who had visited us in the late 1960s on Vikram Sarabhai's invitation. But one I could call my first Russian friend, though his name escapes me now, was a campus mate in Princeton during 1969-70. Doing a graduate programme like me, he never mixed with anyone. That was not unusual for Russians on the campus, because despite their great scientific temper, many of them were not very conversant in English.

U R Rao, too, was keen on a Russian pact. Rao had known the Russians closely from 1972 when he signed the contract to launch India's first satellite Aryabhata by the Russian rocket Kosmos-3M. Aleksandr Dunayev, the chairman of Glavkosmos, the contract company that made rocket engines for the Soviet Union, was not a stranger to India. Dunayev and the agency's administrative officer in charge of cryogenic technology Aleksey V Vasin had visited India a few times on invitation from Vikram Sarabhai.

I had seen Russia as a prospective partner years earlier. During the development of PSLV, when the parallel indigenisation drive was on, I had taken a twelve-member team from different institutes and manufacturing units from India to Russia for familiarisation. It included representatives from Godrej, MTAR, Keltech, HAL, L&T and Walchandnagar Industries. MTAR founder Ravindra Reddy, who had by then demonstrated excellence in delivering some crucial parts of India's space programme and nuclear programme, was also a part of the team. Years later, this visit would help a few Intelligence Bureau officials to drag Reddy into the infamous ISRO spy case of 1994.

For a person who was given the permission by Vikram Sarabhai to build almost an entire nuclear plant, Reddy was, too, impeccable for those IB officers who played puppets in the hands of a foreign agency to be pulled down. Later, they tried to bring in the name of former Indian Prime Minister